



TECHNICAL REPORT

Senso Comune Gallery

Design, commerce and compliance

Unique paintings, sold from mainland China to buyers at home and abroad. What follows is what that costs, what it requires, and what is still unresolved.

Prepared for Priscilla
Date 2026-09-17
Repository `senso-comune-gallery`

Table of contents

1	Summary	1
1.1	What this is	1
1.2	The seven findings that would have sunk it	1
1.3	Decisions taken	2
1.4	Cost	2
2	Design	3
2.1	Where the design came from	3
2.2	The palette	3
2.2.1	What could not be adopted as drawn	5
2.2.2	The warm-ground trap	6
2.3	Typography	6
2.3.1	The scale	6
2.4	The mark	7
2.4.1	The constraint that decides it	7
2.4.2	The options	7
2.4.3	What was chosen	8
2.4.4	Two renderings, one geometry	9
2.4.5	What it deliberately does not do	9
2.4.6	Where it is used	10
2.5	Softness	10
2.5.1	What limits it	10
2.5.2	Research notes	11
2.5.3	Options	12
2.5.4	What was built	15
2.5.5	How it is held	15
2.6	The two masters	16
2.6.1	What was adopted	16
2.6.2	What was cut, and why	17
2.7	The site as built	17
2.8	The design review	17
3	Money	23
3.1	Paying	23
3.1.1	The constraint	23
3.1.2	Route A — launch as an individual	24
3.1.3	Route B — a Hong Kong sole proprietorship	24
3.1.4	Rejected	25
3.2	Shipping	25

3.3	Duty and tax at the border	26
3.4	The donation pledge	27
4	Law and access	29
4.1	Returns	29
4.2	Disclosure	29
4.3	Privacy	30
4.4	Accessibility	30
4.4.1	The legal position	30
4.4.2	What was built	30
4.4.3	Describing a painting	31
5	The build	32
5.1	Shape	32
5.2	The entity switch	32
5.3	Overselling	33
5.4	Checks that block the build	33
6	Open items	35
6.1	Closed since the first draft	35
6.2	Content still outstanding	37
	Appendix: sources and method	38
	Index	39

List of Figures

1	The palette as built. Each value is read from the project's token file, not transcribed.	4
2	Why the sage carries no text. The three red bars are Priscilla's mockup as drawn; the draft's original failure is included for scale.	5
3	Six candidates, each drawn twice: at a size where anyone would approve it, and at 16 px, where it will spend its life.	8
4	Left: how translucent the masthead may be, measured as navigation text over a white passage of a painting. Right: the lightness of a section boundary from top to bottom, before and after. Both panels are computed from the live token file.	11
5	The adopted treatment, with a synthetic stand-in canvas in place of photography that does not exist yet. Left: hover — the navigation underline drawn, the mount lifted, the button raised one pixel. Top right: the glass bar at its scrolled state, with the canvas's near-white highlight beneath it. Bottom right: a section boundary between Original Works and Tribute. . .	15
6	The homepage. Cream sheet mounted on the sage field, dark brown bar, the mark at the head of the wordmark. The first painting sits in the hero beside the motto rather than below the fold; the factual line under the motto is generated from the work data and cannot drift.	18
7	A work page, the painting in its mat. The price is the boldest element in the block — the single change with the best evidence behind it. The scale diagram shows the painting against a 244 cm wall and a 213 cm sofa, hung at the museum standard of 144.78 cm, which is also where the mark's datum sits.	19
8	The sold state. The price stays visible as social proof, "Sold" sits at full contrast in the price position, and the call-to-action slot becomes a capture rather than a dead end.	20
9	Mobile. The masthead is static below 720 px: at 390 px the sticky version grew to 280 px, a third of the viewport, and broke the scroll padding that the focus-obscured criterion depends on. The mark is sized in <code>em</code> , so it shrinks with the wordmark rather than needing its own breakpoint.	21
10	The two routes, and the one string that switches between them.	23
11	How each kind of work travels. The paper rule is the one most often got wrong.	25
12	What a US buyer actually pays on a \$300 painting.	26
13	The How to Buy page, which puts the duty figure in front of the buyer before they commit rather than after.	28
14	Defence in depth. Each layer above the bottom one fails in a way the bottom one survives.	33

List of Tables

1	Blocking findings, in the order they must be dealt with	1
2	Running cost of the recommended build	2
3	Font build, measured rather than estimated	6
4	Type scale, and how close Priscilla's draft already was	6
5	The mark, and where each of its numbers comes from	9
6	Where the homepage's soft edges were hard, before this pass	12
7	Softness options, by area	13
8	What the review changed, by group	20
9	What the individual route does not require	24
10	Import treatment by destination	26
11	Accessibility work, by criterion	30
12	Unresolved, in rough order of cost if wrong	35
13	Closed, and where	36

PART 1

Summary

1.1 What this is

A site selling unique paintings — six in the catalogue at the time of writing, priced \$60–\$440 — run by one non-technical person resident in mainland China, addressed equally to international and domestic buyers.

That last sentence contains most of the difficulty. A gallery site for a handful of works is an afternoon's work. A gallery site for a handful of works that takes money across the Chinese border, ships physical objects internationally, satisfies two consumer-law regimes at once and loads acceptably on both sides of the Great Firewall is not.

Nothing in the build is fixed to six. The count, the year span, the counters and the page set are all derived from the work data; adding a seventh is a data edit.

1.2 The seven findings that would have sunk it

Table 1: Blocking findings, in the order they must be dealt with

Ref	Finding
A-01	Every call to action was #A19E97 — 2.67:1 , failing both the body-text and the large-text floor. No font size rescues it.
B-01	Stripe is unavailable to a mainland-China seller — the whole account, not merely PayPal. Airwallex excludes mainland entities from card acquiring and opens no individual accounts at all.
B-03	<code>vercel.app</code> and <code>workers.dev</code> measure 100% blocked from mainland China. <code>pages.dev</code> measures 0%.
B-05	A unique pre-existing painting gets no returns exception under either Chinese or EU law. Uniqueness is not personalisation.
B-06	Instagram was the only contact channel. It is blocked in mainland China, and EU law requires an email address regardless.
B-08	China-origin paintings are not duty-free into the United States . Section 301 adds 7.5% and the \$800 de minimis exemption is suspended.
N-01	A one-page site cannot link to one painting, which is the site's main acquisition motion.

1.3 Decisions taken

Settled

Launch as an individual, with the Hong Kong entity reachable as a configuration change rather than a rebuild. Under CNY 100,000 annual turnover there is no business-registration requirement, no foreign-exchange quota consumed, no balance-of-payments filing and no VAT.

Host on Cloudflare Pages. The only option with no bill, no pause, no terms problem and no ICP filing.

Seven documents per language, not one. The editorial scroll is kept; two lines of CSS (@view-transition) restore the single-page feel.

Self-host the fonts. 79.8 KB for both families, built from the variable originals.

Adopt Priscilla's sage palette, with text moved onto cream.

1.4 Cost

Table 2: Running cost of the recommended build

Item	One-off	Annual
Hosting (Cloudflare Pages)	\$0	\$0
Domain (registrar at cost)	—	\$11
Fonts, licensing (SIL OFL)	\$0	\$0
Analytics	\$0	\$0
Photography, phone build	\$6–25	—
Photography, full build	\$360–400	—
Copyright registration, batch	\$85	—
Total, minimum viable	\$6–25	\$11

Payment processing is separate and depends on the entity decision; see Section 3.1.

PART 2

Design

2.1 Where the design came from

Priscilla supplied a nine-page draft and, later, a live mockup with a revised palette. Both were treated as the brief. The work here was not to redesign but to find where the drawing and the medium disagree — and they disagreed mostly about contrast.

2.2 The palette

Priscilla's mockup moves the site from white to a sage-green world: a dark brown mast-head bar, warm brown text, terracotta, and cream plates behind the paintings. Two of her decisions were already right and are kept exactly as drawn — the warm browns, and a **filled** terracotta button.

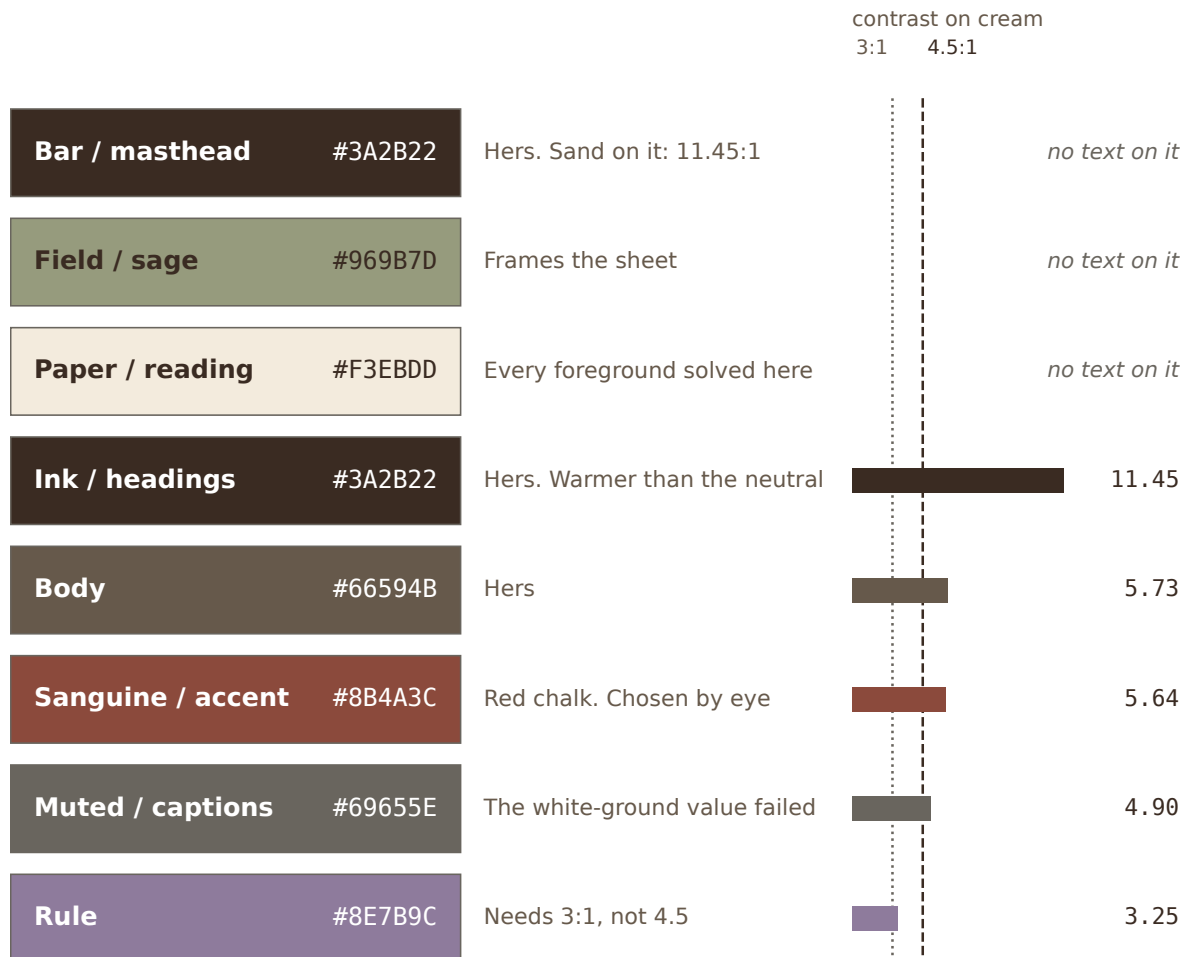


Figure 1: The palette as built. Each value is read from the project's token file, not transcribed.

2.2.1 What could not be adopted as drawn

Body text on the sage does not pass, and the accent on sage is worse than the value it was replacing.

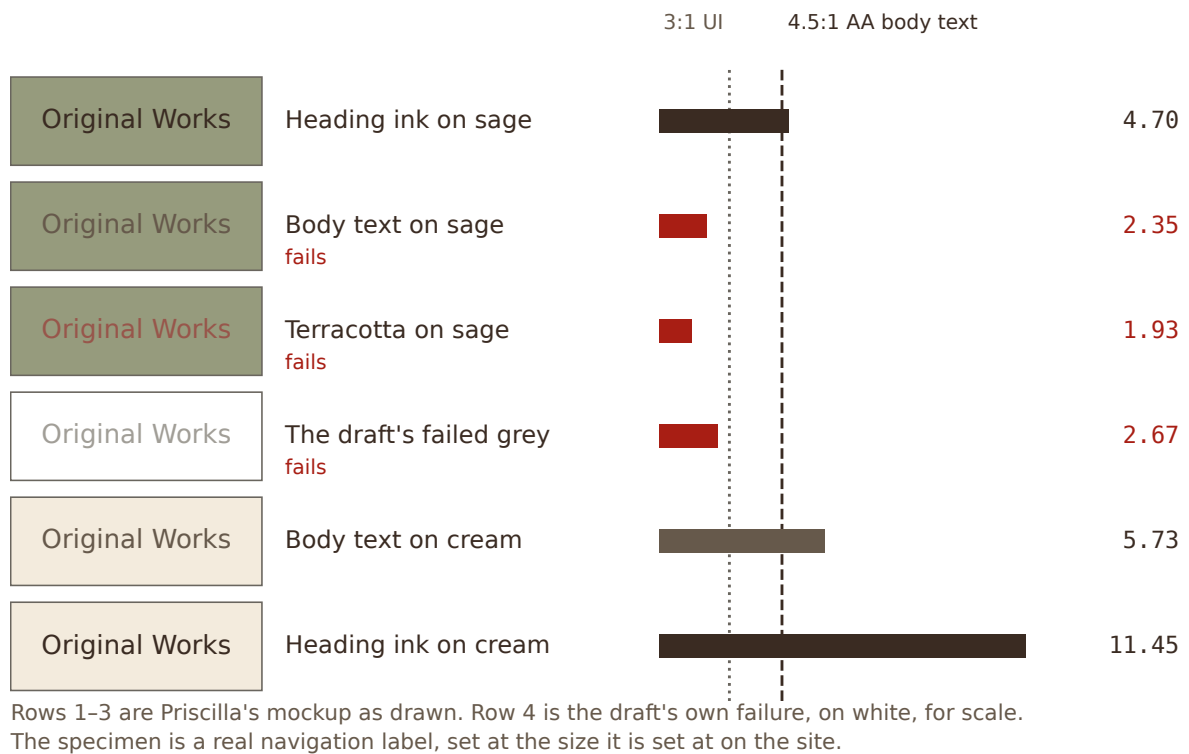


Figure 2: Why the sage carries no text. The three red bars are Priscilla’s mockup as drawn; the draft’s original failure is included for scale.

The resolution was already in her own mockup

She sets the paintings on light cream plates against the sage. So sage becomes the **field** and cream the **reading surface** — the whole content column is a cream sheet mounted on sage, which is what a gallery does to a work on paper anyway.

Her green stays dominant at the margins, the reading happens on cream, and nothing sets text on sage.

2.2.2 The warm-ground trap

#767676 is the canonical “lightest grey that passes on white”. On pure white it passes at 4.54:1, with 0.04 to spare. Warm the ground at all and it fails.

This caught the project three times — twice in tokens written specifically to avoid it. The response was to stop checking by eye: `scripts/check-contrast.mjs` recomputes every token against **the darkest ground it is ever painted on** and fails the build on a regression.

2.3 Typography

Two open-source variable faces, self-hosted: Fraunces and Inter.

Table 3: Font build, measured rather than estimated

Build	Bytes
Fraunces, all four axes	121,124
Fraunces, opsz 14–40, wght 400–700, WONK 1	51,868
Fraunces, opsz pinned	32,500
Inter, opsz 18, wght 400–600	29,856
Total, both families, latin subset	81,724

Two corrections came out of running the build rather than reading about it. The draft sets Fraunces at six optical sizes — 16.0, 16.8, 21.6, 27.2, 30.4 and 38.4 — so the `opsz` axis must stay live; pinning it saves 19 KB and flattens the optical sizing the design depends on. And Fraunces’ `WONK` axis defaults to **1, not 0**; pinning it to 0 changes the letterforms to save 140 bytes.

2.3.1 The scale

Not the golden ratio. The one proportional system in Leonardo’s own hand, on the *Vitruvian Man* sheet, is whole-number fractions of height.

Table 4: Type scale, and how close Priscilla’s draft already was

Role	Fraction	Computed	Draft used
Hero	1 (the height)	38.4 px	38.4 px

Role	Fraction	Computed	Draft used
Section heading	less 1/8	33.6 px	30.4 px
Sub-heading	less 1/4	28.8 px	27.2 px
Wordmark	1/6 + 1/4	22.4 px	21.6 px
Body	the unit	16.8 px	16.8 px
Caption	less 1/4	12.6 px	13.1 px

2.4 The mark

The site had a wordmark and no mark. On a business whose entire acquisition motion is a link in an Instagram or a WeChat bio, the surfaces that render most often are a browser tab, a share card and an avatar — and none of them can render a wordmark.

2.4.1 The constraint that decides it

The wordmark translates: *Senso Comune Gallery* in English, 常识画廊 in Chinese. That was a deliberate decision and it is the right one — a Chinese buyer should not have to read a Latin name to know where they are.

It also settles the logo. A favicon is chosen by **origin**, not by page: one file serves both URL trees, so a site cannot ship one monogram per locale however much it would like to. Any mark built from letterforms therefore serves one audience and decorates the other. *sc* is not the initials of 常识画廊.

This is why the first icon was replaced

The icon shipped in September was *sc*, cut from real Fraunces outlines. It was a correct solution to the problem as stated — *make something that reads at 16 px* — and it reads at 16 px. It was the wrong solution to the problem as it actually is, which is *make something that reads at 16 px in two languages*.

2.4.2 The options

Six were drawn. Four of them are eliminated by the same column of Figure 3 — the one that shows each candidate at the size it will actually be rendered at most of the time.

at display size 16 px



Wordmark alone

WHERE THE SITE STARTED

Nothing to put in a tab. Illegible below about 90 px, and there is no second lockup for a share card or a WeChat avatar.



SC monogram

WHAT SHIPPED IN SEPTEMBER

Reads at 16 px. But the wordmark translates, and the Chinese one is not spelled with Latin letters at all. It serves one of the two audiences.



One monogram per locale

THE OBVIOUS REPAIR

Two marks is two brands. The favicon is chosen by the origin, not by the page, so a bilingual site cannot swap it per locale anyway.



Leonardo's hatching

THE DEBT, MADE LITERAL

Announces the reference the brief asked to be carried quietly, and at 16 px it is four grey lines.



Sfumato disc

THE PRINCIPLE, MADE LITERAL

A soft edge cannot survive a 32 px ICO, a monochrome fax of an invoice or an embroidered label. It has no outline to fall back to.



A work on a wall

RECOMMENDED

Carries no letterforms, so one file serves both locales. Its proportions are the catalogue's own: a 3:4 portrait hung at 144.78 cm on a 244 cm wall.

Figure 3: Six candidates, each drawn twice: at a size where anyone would approve it, and at 16 px, where it will spend its life.

2.4.3 What was chosen

A work on a wall — the site's own structure, which is a cream sheet mounted on a sage field, reduced to three rectangles. It carries no letterforms, so one file serves both locales and it cannot fall back to the wrong typeface.

Nothing in it is arbitrary. Every number is one the project had already committed to somewhere else.

Table 5: The mark, and where each of its numbers comes from

Element	Value	Source
Wall	64 × 64, <code>--bar</code>	The masthead. A piece of the site, not a badge applied to it
Plate	28 × 37.33 — 3:4 — <code>--paper</code>	The modal aspect of the catalogue, every work in which is portrait
Datum	Full width, <code>--field</code> , at 59.34 %	144.78 cm on a 244 cm wall — the museum hanging standard the work-page scale diagram is already drawn to

The datum runs the full width and passes *behind* the plate, so what is visible is two short sage segments either side of the work. That is what a hanging line looks like on a real wall, and it is the detail that stops the mark reading as a generic picture-frame glyph.

2.4.4 Two renderings, one geometry

The wall is a **fill** where it can be seen and an **outline** where it cannot. In the tab, on the home screen and in this document's footer, the wall is painted. On the site's own masthead the ground is already `--bar`, so a filled wall would be no wall at all; there it is drawn as a 1.5-unit sage outline and everything else is identical.

Both are generated from `scripts/mark.mjs`. The report reads the same file — Figure 3 is drawn from it, not from a copy of its numbers — so the document cannot end up arguing for a mark the site no longer ships.

2.4.5 What it deliberately does not do

- **It spends no accent.** Sanguine is 2.03:1 on the bar and would disappear at tab size; the sage datum is 4.70:1. The accent stays reserved for calls to action, which is most of what this palette is for.
- **It depends on no font.** An SVG favicon is rendered *without* the page's webfonts, so a mark set as `<text>` falls back to whatever serif the operating system has. Three rectangles and a line have no such failure mode.
- **It has no per-locale variant**, by construction. Section 2.4.1 is the reason, and the build asserts it: the masthead lockup is byte-identical on the English and Chinese home-pages.

WCAG contrast is defined on relative luminance, so converting the mark to greyscale leaves both of its ratios exactly where they are — 11.45:1 and 4.70:1 — and it survives a monochrome print unchanged. Two cases have **not** been tested: single-ink reproduction, where plate and datum cannot be separated by lightness at all, and embroidery below about 15 mm. Neither is needed before launch.

2.4.6 Where it is used

`icon.svg`, `favicon.ico` at 32 px, `apple-touch-icon.png` at 180 px and `site.webmanifest`, all from one source; the masthead lockup, where the mark and the name are a single link and a single tab stop; and this document, in the footer of every page and on the title page.

Eight assertions in `scripts/check-review.mjs` hold it together: that the icon is the geometry `mark.mjs` declares, that the masthead draws the same plate, that the mark contributes no accessible name of its own, that it is identical in both locales, that it spends no accent, and that the hanging figure is the one the work pages cite.

2.5 Softness

The site as first built was correct and a little hard: square sheet, flat works, a colour swap for a hover and hard stops where sections met. This pass asked for something softer and more elegant — without making it less professional, and without changing a single colour.

Those two constraints do most of the design work. Every familiar softening technique reaches for new colour (a white card, a black shadow, a coloured glow) or for lower contrast (translucency), and this site has already argued, with measurements, against both.

2.5.1 What limits it

Three commitments made earlier in this document bound what “soft” may mean here.

- **Quietness is bought with size and whitespace, never with contrast.** Anything translucent puts text over a ground that is no longer a token, so its contrast has to be measured against the worst thing that can pass beneath it — which, on a site of paintings, is white.
- **Edges dissolve rather than rule** (Section 2.6). A softer site should have *fewer* lines, not decorative new ones.
- **A painting is never altered.** Rounding its corner crops it. Zooming it on hover implies it was cropped to fit. Stretching it misrepresents the object for sale.

Motion has its own limit, already recorded in the stylesheet: many viewport-heights of large images make scroll-triggered movement a vestibular risk, and every animation must stand down when the reader has asked for reduced motion.

2.5.2 Research notes

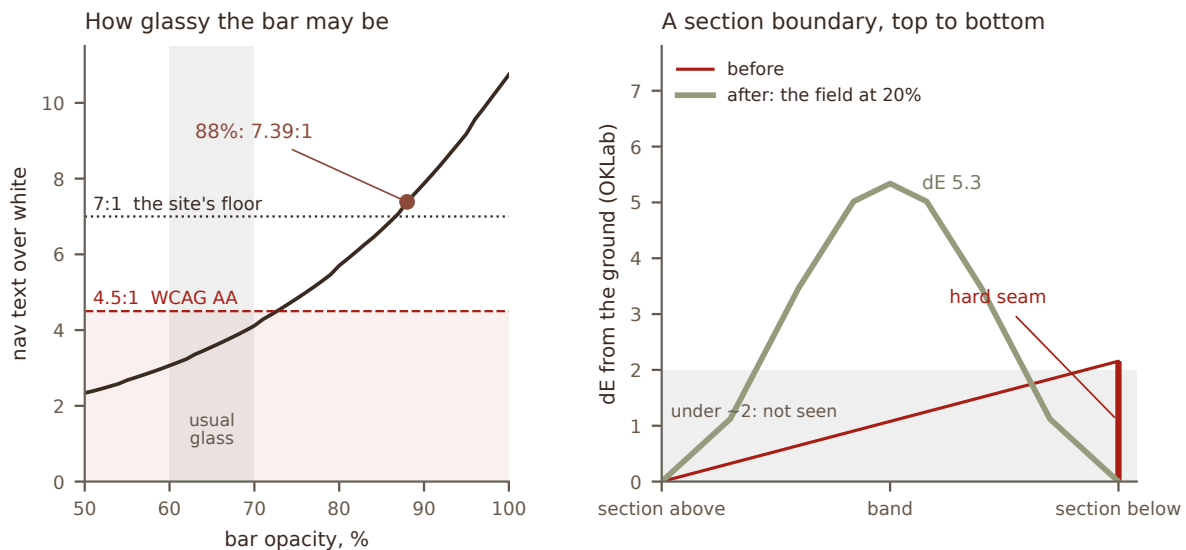


Figure 4: Left: how translucent the masthead may be, measured as navigation text over a white passage of a painting. Right: the lightness of a section boundary from top to bottom, before and after. Both panels are computed from the live token file.

Glass has a hard floor, and it is high. The usual glassmorphism panel runs at 60–70% opacity. Over a white passage that puts the navigation at 3.06–4.11:1: a failure at caption size. WCAG's 4.5:1 is reached at 73%; a full AAA margin of 7:1 needs 87%. The glass that is legal here is subtle by necessity, and the right-hand side of Figure 4 is why it is still worth having: a painting passing under a solid bar is cut off by a slab, while under 88% it is *felt* as a soft blur of its own colour.

Glass at rest would repaint the brand. Prototyping showed a problem no contrast figure reveals: a translucent bar at the top of the page sits over the sage, so every page would show a greyed, greenish masthead instead of Priscilla's brown. Glass is only wanted once there is something beneath it.

The old section boundaries were invisible and hard at once. The washes the sfumato bands faded between differ by ΔE 0.8–2.6 in OKLab — at or under the threshold of perception when spread across 9 rem. A boundary was therefore only ever seen where it

broke. Sampling the rendered homepage row by row found four such breaks, each a 10-level hard step (Table 6). The “soft edge” was being read as a faint line.

Table 6: Where the homepage's soft edges were hard, before this pass

Boundary	Seam	Cause
Hero → Works	#ECE3D2 → #F3EBDD	The band faded to violet; the section below is warm
Tribute → archive link	#EDE4D3 → #F3EBDD	The link sat outside Tribute, on the bare sheet
Archive link → About	#F3EBDD → #ECE3D3	...so the next band started violet against warm
About → How to Buy	#E9E3D6 → #F3EBDD	No band at all

A peak reads as a crease. A boundary that rises and falls through a few evenly weighted stops draws a pointed profile, and the eye finds the point. The adopted band follows a raised cosine across nine stops, which is what the right-hand panel of Figure 4 plots — read back out of the stylesheet rather than redrawn.

Motion on this site must settle, not perform. The motion tokens already say *leave quickly, settle slowly, never overshoot*. Cross-document view transitions let a painting carry from the list into its own page. They need a unique name per element on each page; two elements sharing a name abort the whole transition, which rules out naming the lightbox copy.

2.5.3 Options

Every option considered is listed. **Adopted** items are built. **Optional** items remain available for a later pass, and where one fails a measured limit the reason says so.

Table 7: Softness options, by area

Area	Option	Status	Why
Edges	2 px on controls and panels, 3 px on the sheet	Adopted	Softens the pixel-hard corner without changing shape; a mount board is square
Edges	8–16 px radii	Optional	Reads as an app, not a gallery
Edges	Rounded corners on the paintings	Optional — <i>crops the work</i>	Rounding a corner removes part of the object being sold
Elevation	Three-layer shadows tinted with --bar	Adopted	A brown shadow sits <i>in</i> the paper; a black one sits on it and reads grey
Elevation	Single large neutral shadow	Optional	Reads as a glow
Margins	Passe-partout: a --paper-deep mat, no outline	Adopted	What a gallery does to a work; defined by tone and shadow, not a line
Margins	--paper mat with a hairline	Optional	Crisper and more card-like, but adds the line the site avoids
Margins	Shadow only, no mat	Optional	Softer still; loses the mounted look
Margins	Sheet floating from 900 px, not 1320 px	Adopted	On a 1280 px laptop the sheet used to run into the bar
Glass	Masthead at 88%, scroll-driven, desktop	Adopted	7.39:1 over white; solid at rest; nothing passes under it on a phone
Glass	Masthead at 60–70%	Optional — <i>fails 4.5:1</i>	3.06–4.11:1 over a white passage
Glass	Translucent reading panels over the sage	Optional — <i>unbounded contrast</i>	The sheet is the reading surface; text on glass over a painting has no worst case to solve against
Boundaries	The field breathing through each band at 20%	Adopted	ΔE 5.3: plainly there when scrolling, a fifth of the way to the sage

Area	Option	Status	Why
Boundaries	Bands named by, and fading between, their actual neighbours	Adopted	Removes all four seams in Table 6
Boundaries	Each section its own sheet, with sage between	Optional	The most emphatic; replaces one mounted sheet with several and doubles the shadows
Boundaries	The mark set small at the centre of a band	Optional	A signpost that repeats the logo on every scroll
Boundaries	A hairline or short sanguine rule	Optional — <i>adds a line and spends the accent</i>	Contradicts both principles above
Motion	Nav underline drawn in from the left	Adopted	A transform, so nothing reflows and the 48 px target is unchanged
Motion	One-pixel button lift, pointer devices only	Adopted	On touch, <code>:hover</code> sticks after a tap
Motion	Mount shadow deepens when a work is hovered	Adopted	Elevation without touching the painting
Motion	Lightbox fades and settles 8 px	Adopted	No scale: a painting drawn at 99.5% is drawn wrong
Motion	Zoom a painting on hover	Optional — <i>alters the work</i>	Implies cropping; no hover on touch
Motion	Scroll-triggered reveals, parallax	Optional — <i>vestibular risk</i>	Also invisible in a link-card thumbnail and the first frame
Motion	Animated focus ring	Optional — <i>not recommended</i>	A focus indicator must be present the instant focus arrives
Navigation	Masthead held still across page changes	Adopted	Without it the whole bar dissolves and re-forms, which reads as a reload
Navigation	The painting carried from list to page	Adopted	Chromium and Safari; elsewhere navigation is simply instant
Navigation	Smooth scrolling for in-page jumps	Optional	A long glide past many large images; already declined

2.5.4 What was built

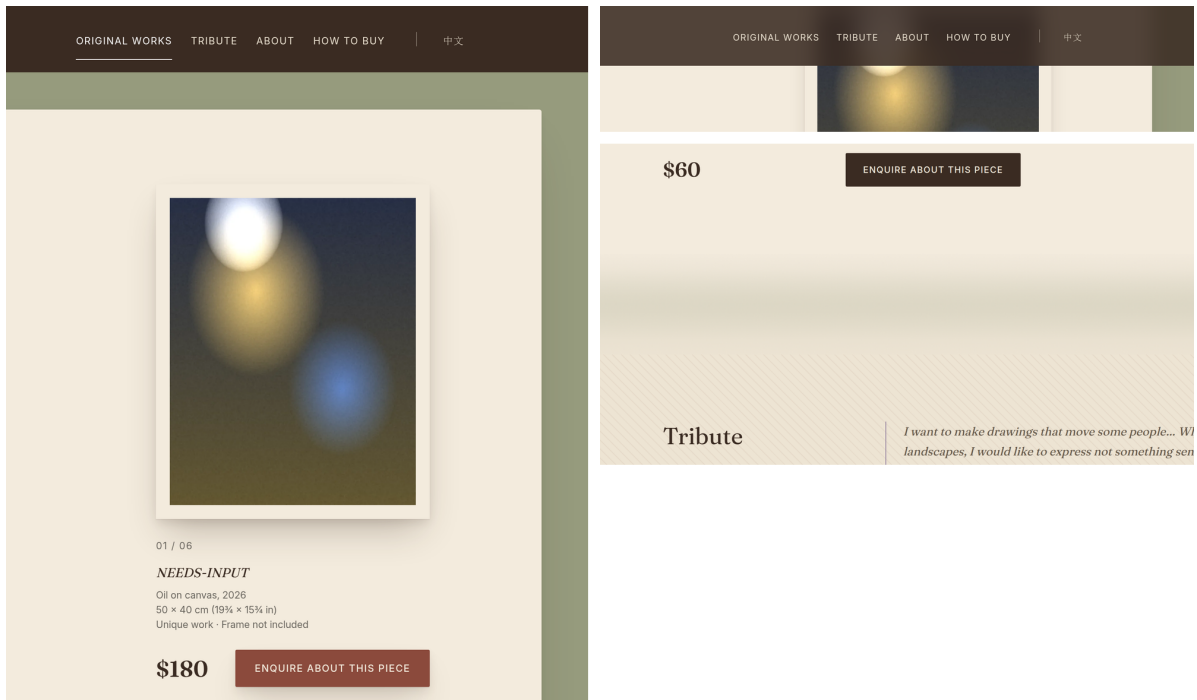


Figure 5: The adopted treatment, with a synthetic stand-in canvas in place of photography that does not exist yet. Left: hover — the navigation underline drawn, the mount lifted, the button raised one pixel. Top right: the glass bar at its scrolled state, with the canvas's near-white highlight beneath it. Bottom right: a section boundary between Original Works and Tribute.

Nothing in the palette changed. All nine new softness tokens — two radii, three shadows, the mat, the glass opacity and blur, and the boundary breath — are expressed through colours that already existed, and a check fails the build if a literal colour appears among them.

2.5.5 How it is held

- `check-contrast.mjs` composites the bar at `--glass-bar-opacity` over pure white and fails the build below 7:1 for navigation text. Set to the usual 70%, it names three failures.
- `check-render.mjs` is new, and the first check that needs a browser. It lays the built pages out in Chrome at 1440, 900 and 390 px and asserts that every painting's box keeps the painting's own proportions to within 1%, with no radius and no transform. It is not part of `npm run check`, which must run anywhere; CI runs it on every deploy.

Forcing the hero full-width under its height cap makes it report a 17% distortion by name.

- Six assertions in `check-review.mjs` (G-01 to G-06) cover the rest: no literal colour in the new tokens, a mat and nothing that alters a painting, glass solid at rest and gated, all new motion standing down for reduced motion, one transition name per painting per page, and every band joining the grounds actually either side of it. Each was mutation-tested.

2.6 The two masters

The brief asked for a debt to Leonardo and to van Gogh, carried without ever announcing itself. The test applied throughout: *a visitor who knows nothing should feel only that the site is calm and well made; a visitor who knows the work should feel recognised.*

2.6.1 What was adopted

- **The accent is sanguine.** Red chalk, the medium Leonardo drew in, measures 6.33:1 on white; the oxblood Priscilla chose by eye measures 6.68:1. They are the same colour. The recommendation was to change nothing and record why.
- **No hard edges.** Leonardo's instruction to paint "*without strokes or lines, in the manner of smoke*" and the Chinese 没骨 ("boneless") tradition of painting without contour are the same idea reached independently. For a Chinese painter addressing both audiences that is a structural principle, not a motif. Section boundaries dissolve rather than rule.
- **The rules are van Gogh's stated violet.** He told Theo the *Bedroom* walls were "of a pale violet"; they read blue today because the red lake faded. The site uses the colour he said, not the colour that survived.
- **Hatching runs his way.** Leonardo was left-handed, so his stroke runs upper-left to lower-right. No text source could be retrieved, so the 43.8° angle is an original structure-tensor measurement of his sheets, validated against a right-handed control.

2.6.2 What was cut, and why

The myth filter

Golden-ratio grid. Unsupported. Illustrating Pacioli's *De divina proportione* establishes that Leonardo drew the solids, not that he composed on the ratio.

"Leonardo invented sfumato", and the word itself. Cennino Cennini described blending shadows like smoke a century earlier, and Leonardo never used the noun — a full-text search of the *Trattato* returns none.

Any yellow as text. Indian yellow is 2.10:1 and zinc yellow 1.53:1. Both are genuine *Starry Night* pigments and both are unusable for anything but a mark inside an image.

Sampling colours off the paintings. The *Bedroom* wall as it survives today is 2.78:1; the *Sunflowers* chrome yellow 2.70:1. Both sit within a hair of the 2.67:1 failure this report opens with.

2.7 The site as built

Four views, at the two widths the layout was verified at. The screenshots are of the built pages, not mockups: what is shown is what `npm run build` produces — `docs/report/shots.sh` takes them from `dist/` over a real origin, so this section cannot quietly describe a version of the site that no longer exists.

2.8 The design review

The built site was reviewed again in September, as a designer rather than as its author, and the twenty findings were implemented. They are recorded here because several of them change claims made earlier in this document.

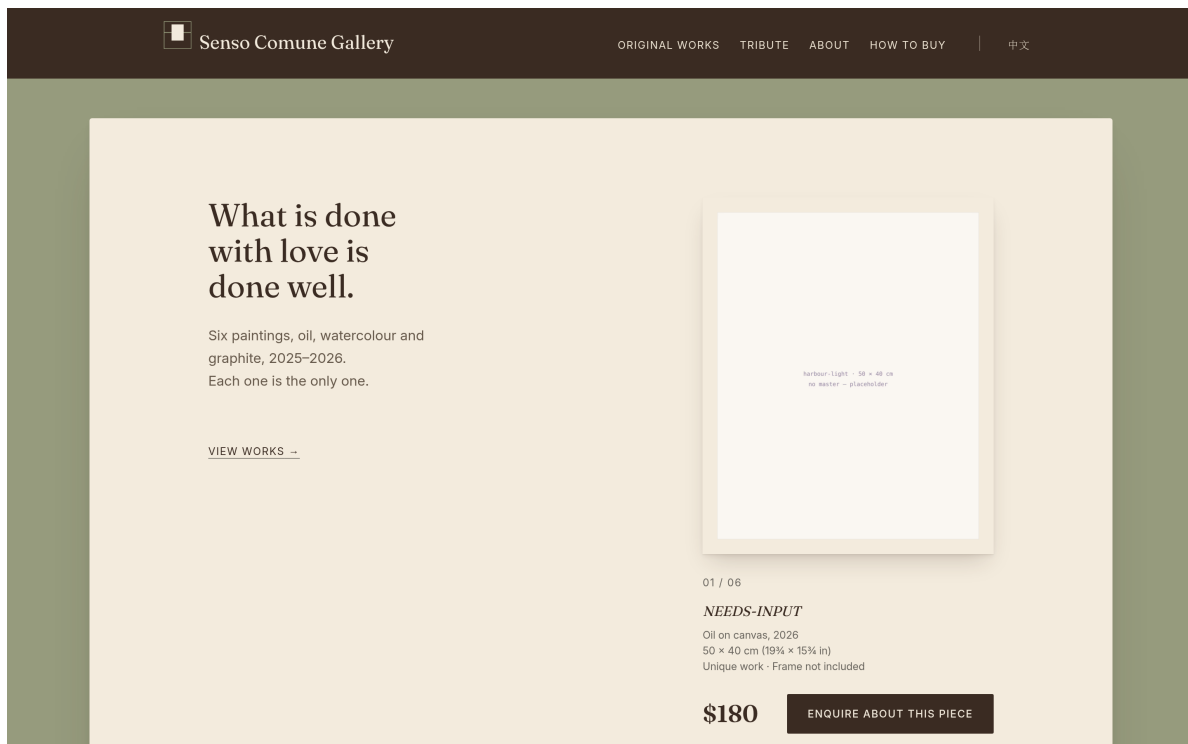


Figure 6: The homepage. Cream sheet mounted on the sage field, dark brown bar, the mark at the head of the wordmark. The first painting sits in the hero beside the motto rather than below the fold; the factual line under the motto is generated from the work data and cannot drift.

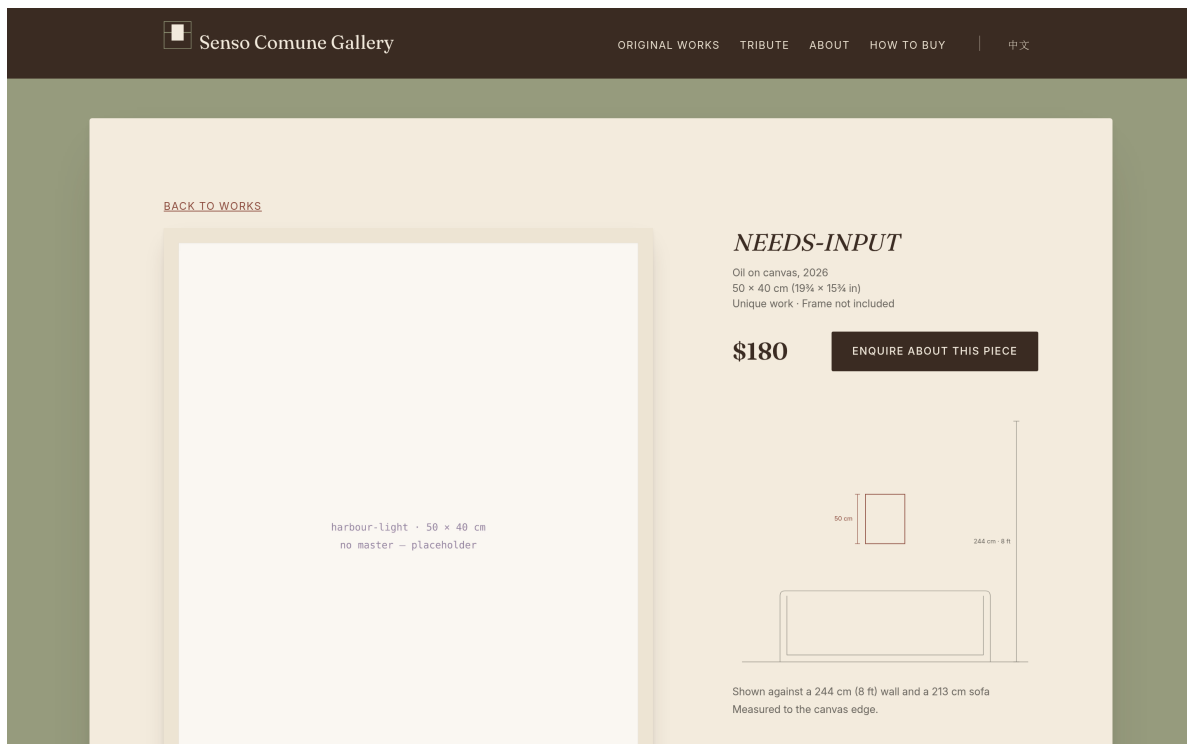


Figure 7: A work page, the painting in its mat. The price is the boldest element in the block — the single change with the best evidence behind it. The scale diagram shows the painting against a 244 cm wall and a 213 cm sofa, hung at the museum standard of 144.78 cm, which is also where the mark's datum sits.

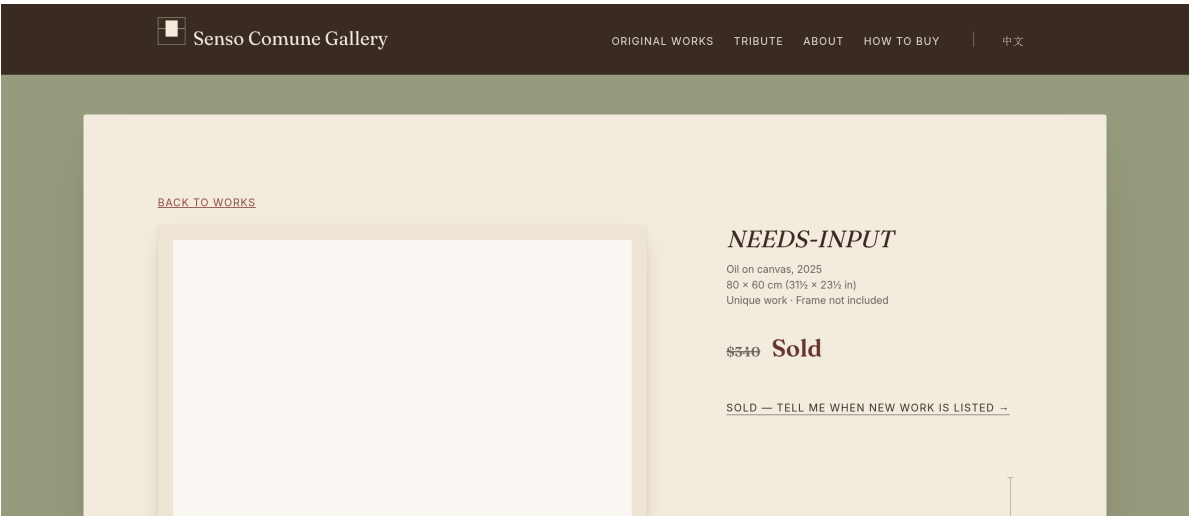


Figure 8: The sold state. The price stays visible as social proof, “Sold” sits at full contrast in the price position, and the call-to-action slot becomes a capture rather than a dead end.

Table 8: What the review changed, by group

Group	No.	What shipped
A Selling	4	A painting moved into the hero beside the motto; a <code>mailto:</code> link stopped calling itself <i>Buy</i> ; How to Buy gained reachable contact details; the price and its button were bound into one block
B Contrast and craft	4	A footer grey at 2.34:1 — shipped, not theoretical — was removed; the contrast checker was taught to resolve the cascade rather than read declarations; the scale diagram’s linework went from 1.73:1 to 3.24:1 and its labels from 3.05:1 to 4.90:1
C Reach	4	The icon set, <code>theme-color</code> and manifest (Section 2.4); Open Graph typed as a product with price and availability; the sage field restored on a phone
D Reading	5	Prose pages given a narrower mount; the archive set as a grid rather than a second selling gallery; the gallery name made the <code>h1</code> ; dead rules deleted
E Fonts	2	The Chinese subset’s coverage is now asserted at build time, and each locale preloads only the face it uses
F The mark	4	Section 2.4

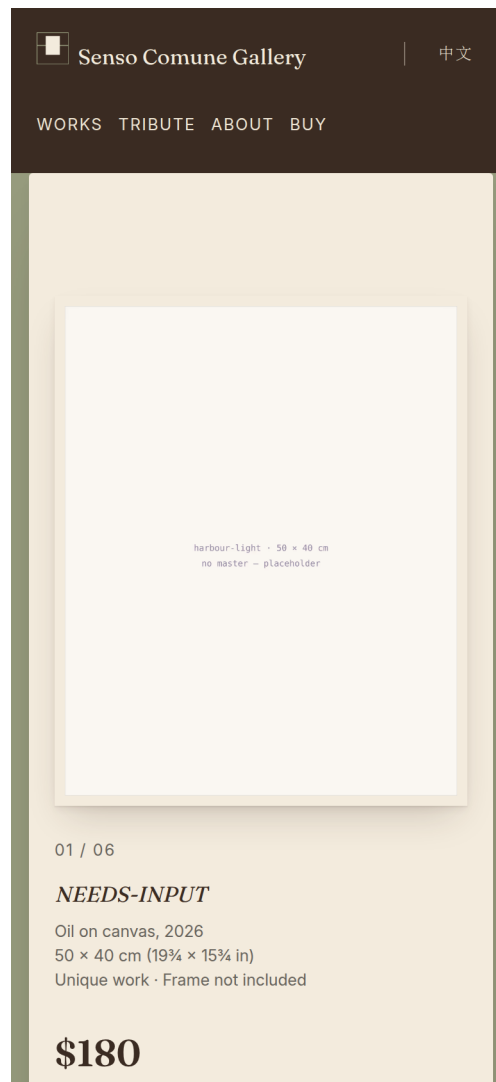


Figure 9: Mobile. The masthead is static below 720 px: at 390 px the sticky version grew to 280 px, a third of the viewport, and broke the scroll padding that the focus-obscured criterion depends on. The mark is sized in `em`, so it shrinks with the wordmark rather than needing its own breakpoint.

Two of the twenty were not fixes. **C-04** proposed freezing the wordmark in English; it was declined, and the wordmark still translates — which is what later decided the logo. And half of **B-03** was simply wrong: the review claimed the scale diagram's painting and sofa were composed off-axis. They are both centred, and always were. The contrast half of that finding was real and is the measurement above.

PART 3

Money

3.1 Paying

3.1.1 The constraint

B-01 · Stripe is not available

Mainland China is absent from Stripe's supported business countries. Hong Kong, Singapore and Japan are present. This is not the narrower finding about PayPal — it is the whole account.

Airwallex looked like the answer and is more restricted than it appears. A mainland entity can open an account for Global Accounts, foreign exchange and transfers, but card acquiring is excluded in Airwallex's own Chinese-language terms, and it opens no personal accounts at all.

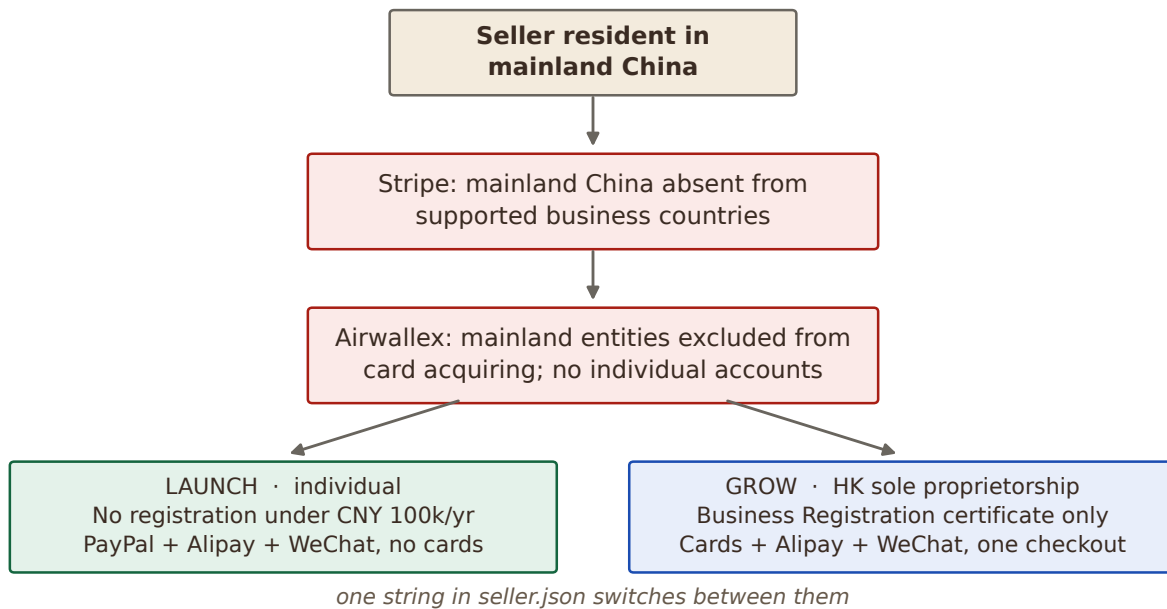


Figure 10: The two routes, and the one string that switches between them.

3.1.2 Route A — launch as an individual

At this turnover, four obligations that would normally apply do not.

Table 9: What the individual route does not require

Requirement	Position	Authority
Business registration	Not required under CNY 100,000/yr online turnover	SAMR Order 37, Art. 8 ¶13
FX annual quota	Not consumed — cross-border e-commerce settles outside it	汇发〔2020〕14号 Art. 66(2)
BOP declaration	Not filed — resident individuals exempt at or below USD 10,000 per transaction	汇发〔2022〕22号 Art. 8
VAT	Exempt — monthly sales under CNY 100,000, to 31 Dec 2027	财政部/税务总局 2023 年第 19 号

Six works at \$60–\$440 is roughly CNY 19,000 — an order of magnitude below the registration ceiling.

What Priscilla must not do

Route sale proceeds as a gift or family remittance; split transactions to stay under a threshold; or use informal currency swaps. The last is 私自买卖外汇 under Article 45 of the FX Regulations, and published enforcement puts the penalty on the offender's PBOC credit file.

3.1.3 Route B — a Hong Kong sole proprietorship

A Business Registration certificate is sufficient — no incorporation. That unlocks the free Airwallex plan with no-code payment links, international cards at 3.60% + HK\$2.35, and **Alipay and WeChat Pay** as merchant methods, which is how the domestic half of the audience is served from one checkout.

It also unlocks repatriation: Airwallex supports local CNY transfer for sellers without a mainland registered business whose ultimate beneficial owner is a Chinese national exporting goods from the mainland. That describes this business exactly.

Confirm before incorporating

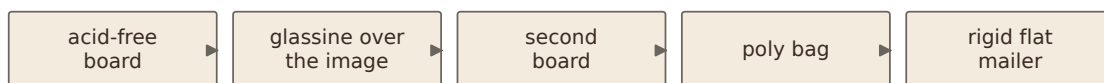
Airwallex approves its Payments product **separately** from account opening, and reviews the live site as part of that review. The entity list verified covers account opening only.

3.1.4 Rejected

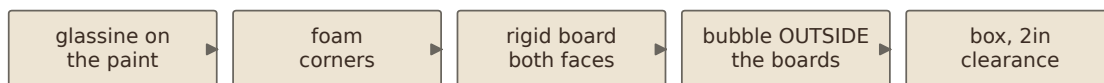
Payoneer Checkout is Stripe-powered, excludes mainland China explicitly, and requires monthly volumes above USD 20,000 — roughly 130× this business. **PingPong** and **Lian-Lian** both have real independent-site acquiring, but neither publishes pricing or eligibility and both are sales-led. Do not design around either without a written quote.

3.2 Shipping**Works on paper**

flat, never rolled — rolling cracks the sizing

**Stretched canvas**

upright, never flat — and never below freezing



Materials run \$25-50 per shipment. Every carrier's artwork declared-value caps sits above this inventory.

Figure 11: How each kind of work travels. The paper rule is the one most often got wrong.

Works on paper ship flat, never rolled

Rolling cracks the paper's sizing and can crease or smear the media. Tubes are a fallback for very large **unstretched** canvas only.

Stretched canvas ships upright, never flat, with the bubble wrap outside the rigid boards so nothing touches the paint. Cold is a real hazard: linseed oil stiffens and can crack below freezing, which matters for winter shipping.

The much-discussed “\$1,000 artwork cap” does not bind here. FedEx caps declared value on art at \$1,000 or \$9.07/lb, whichever is greater; USPS additional insurance for artwork caps around \$1,000. Every one of those caps sits above this entire inventory.

3.3 Duty and tax at the border

B-08 · The site cannot say “duty-free” to US buyers

Original paintings under HS 9701 carry a **Free** base rate, which is where the belief comes from. For a **China-origin** shipment in 2026 it is wrong.

- **Section 301 List 4A applies.** HTSUS 9903.88.15 imposes **+7.5%** on products of China, and US note 20(s)(i) enumerates 9701.91.00 — contemporary paintings — among the covered subheadings. The exclusion that once covered paintings is expired.
- **De minimis is suspended.** The \$800 exemption no longer applies, so every painting needs a customs entry.
- **The IEEPA tariffs are gone** — struck down and revoked in February 2026 — and artworks were separately carved out of them as “informational materials”. That relief does **not** extend to Section 301.

A \$300 painting, China origin, delivered to the United States



Figure 12: What a US buyer actually pays on a \$300 painting.

Table 10: Import treatment by destination

Destination	Duty	VAT / tax	Confidence
United States	+7.5% Section 301	—	Verified

Destination	Duty	VAT / tax	Confidence
United Kingdom	0%, ERGA OMNES (origin-neutral)	Reduced art rate	Verified
European Union	0% expected	Reduced art rate per member state	Unverified — see Section 6

3.4 The donation pledge

The draft said “10% of each order goes toward research”, which is a per-transaction consumer promise. The site now says *“I personally donate 10% of my profits each quarter”* — a personal pledge, which is a materially different representation.

What protects the pledge is not the wording but the receipts: a public page with the recipient named, the basis stated, the cadence disclosed, and a running cumulative total.

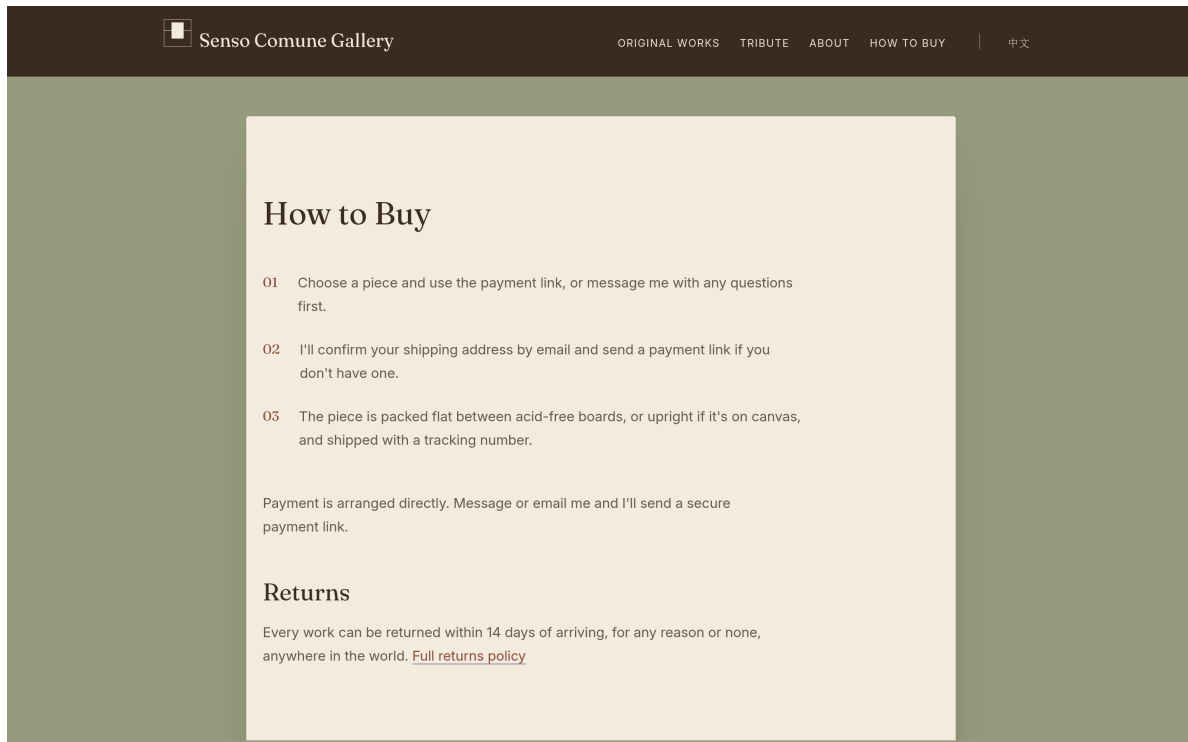


Figure 13: The How to Buy page, which puts the duty figure in front of the buyer before they commit rather than after.

PART 4

Law and access

4.1 Returns

B-05 · Returns cannot be refused, in either market

China. Consumer Protection Law Art. 25 gives a seven-day no-reason return on distance sales. The exceptions are a **closed list** — SAIC Order 90 Art. 6 excludes only goods made to the consumer's order, perishables, unsealed digital media and delivered periodicals. The 2024 Implementing Regulations Art. 19 then expressly forbid a trader expanding that list, and ban pre-ticked exclusion.

European Union. CRD Art. 16(c) excepts goods "made to the consumer's specifications or clearly personalised". **Uniqueness is not personalisation** — the test is whether the *buyer* specified it. A pre-existing painting chosen from a catalogue of six fails that test.

A "governed by PRC law" clause does not help: Rome I Art. 6(2) prevents a choice of law from depriving a consumer of protections that cannot be derogated from under their home law, where the trader directs activity there. Offering EU shipping at checkout is directing activity.

One worldwide 14-day policy over-satisfies the Chinese seven days, removes any need to geo-detect buyers, and avoids a seven-day policy reading as an attempt to shorten the EU right. Commissions are the one genuine exception under both regimes.

4.2 Disclosure

One block of address, phone and email satisfies three regimes at once: the EU Consumer Rights Directive Art. 6(1)(c), the Chinese requirement, and the UK anticipatory duty. Alongside it, SAMR Order 37 Art. 12 prescribes the exact sentence an unregistered individual seller must publish:

个人从事零星小额交易活动，依法不需要办理市场主体登记

That string is quoted verbatim from the rule and must not be paraphrased.

4.3 Privacy

PIPL applies, and costs a privacy page and a one-page impact assessment — no more. Processing necessary to conclude and perform the sale needs **no consent checkbox** — a just-in-time notice at the email field is the correct pattern, and consent is reserved for the newsletter. No PRC representative and no regulator filing are required, because those provisions bind handlers *outside* China. The overseas hosting is exempt from the CAC transfer mechanisms both as contract-necessary and on volume.

4.4 Accessibility

4.4.1 The legal position

Calmer than the compliance industry suggests. A one-person operation is almost certainly exempt from the European Accessibility Act as a microenterprise providing services. The stronger argument for the work is commercial: **a blind collector who cannot read the descriptions cannot buy the painting.**

4.4.2 What was built

Table 11: Accessibility work, by criterion

Criterion	What it required	Status
1.4.3 Contrast	Every CTA was 2.67:1	Filled ink control at 11.45:1
1.4.1 Use of colour	No accent reaches 3:1 against body text	Underlines on body links, structurally
2.4.7 / 1.4.11 Focus	A single-colour ring dies over a dark painting	Two-tone ring, works on any ground
2.4.11 Focus not obscured	Sticky nav can hide the focused item	<code>scroll-padding-top</code> ; static on mobile
2.5.8 Target size	Nav bars are not sentences; the inline exception does not apply	48 px via padding
1.1.1 Non-text content	Six paintings, no alt text	Three-layer description per work
2.4.4 Link purpose	Six identical “Buy” links in the links list	Visually-hidden span per control

4.4.3 Describing a painting

The “125-character limit” is folklore — there is none in the HTML specification or in WCAG. The citable number is Cooper Hewitt’s **approximately fifteen words**.

The guidance genuinely disagrees on interpretation: the DIAGRAM Center says never interpret, Cooper Hewitt says interpret when it aids visual understanding. For an artist’s own gallery Cooper Hewitt is right — but interpretation stays textually separable, labelled “Artist’s note”, placed last, and never allowed to replace observation.

On AI-drafted descriptions

Acceptable as a first pass, never as shipped text. A model can report palette, format and apparent handling. It cannot know the true medium, the real dimensions, the title, or the intent — which is exactly what a buyer needs. A wrong description is worse than none, because it burns trust in the channel.

PART 5

The build

5.1 Shape

Plain Node, no framework. Twenty-eight pages generated from three data files, with sharp the only runtime dependency — which is the only architecture consistent with a design whose argument is restraint.

```
src/data/          seller.json · artworks.json · site.json
src/styles/        tokens.css · base.css · gallery.css
src/templates.js
build.js           28 pages, two locales
scripts/           mark.mjs           the logo geometry, shared with the report
                  build-fonts · build-fonts-cjk · build-images · build-icons
                  check-contrast · check-links · check-review · check-render
                  preview.mjs          one page, inlined, for review
docs/              brief/ · build-report/ · report/      one document each
```

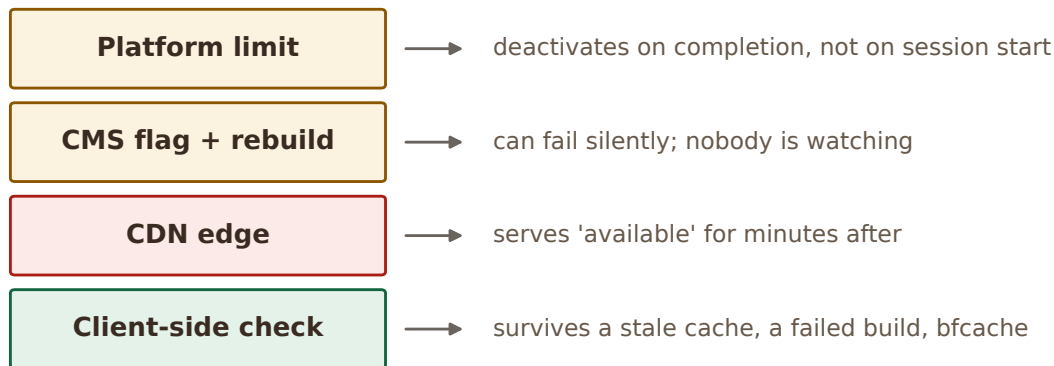
The page count follows the catalogue: fourteen routes per locale for six works, of which six are work pages.

5.2 The entity switch

One string in `seller.json` moves the whole site between the two commercial routes:

```
"activeEntity": "individual" → "hk-sole-prop"
```

That switches the published legal disclosure, the invoicing language, the checkout provider and the returns basis together. No template knows which entity is active.



No platform in this price range guarantees atomicity. The bottom layer is the cheapest, and the only one that survives the other three failing.

Figure 14: Defence in depth. Each layer above the bottom one fails in a way the bottom one survives.

5.3 Overselling

No platform in this price range guarantees atomicity. The client-side availability check is roughly forty lines and is the only layer that survives a stale CDN page, a silently failed rebuild or a bfcache restore.

Alongside it, a published policy costs nothing and settles the residual case: *in the rare event two people buy the same piece at once, the first completed payment stands and the second is refunded in full within 24 hours.*

5.4 Checks that block the build

Four. `npm run check` runs the first three anywhere; the fourth needs a browser and runs in CI.

`check-contrast.mjs` recomputes every token against its worst-case ground. It also resolves the *cascade*: where several rules set a colour on the dark bar, it takes the declaration that actually wins and measures that one.

`check-links.mjs` verifies dead links, missing `alt`, missing `width` or `height`, heading order, landmark counts, hreflang reciprocity, and that the shipped Chinese subset still covers every CJK character the build puts in a display position.

`check-review.mjs` is newer and differently shaped: **47 assertions over 30 findings** — the design review (Section 2.8), the mark and the softness pass — written against the

built pages rather than the source, so a fix that silently stops being applied fails the build instead of being noticed in a screenshot months later.

`check-render.mjs` lays the built pages out in headless Chrome and fails if any painting is drawn out of its own proportions, rounded or transformed (Section 2.5.5).

Between them they caught a muted grey that passed on white and failed on the darkest wash, work pages shipping with no `<h1>` at all, and a mobile override that made the navigation invisible once the dark bar was adopted.

A test that passes for the wrong reason

One of the review fixes set `font-size:var(--size-h1)`. No such token exists — the scale calls it `--size-hero` — so the rule silently fell back to inherited body size, and the assertion written for it passed because it only matched the declaration's text. The repair was a cross-cutting assertion that every `var(--token)` in the shipped stylesheet resolves to a definition. An undefined custom property is the one CSS error that produces no error.

The limit of automation

Automated testing decides roughly 13–30% of WCAG success criteria and catches almost none of the focus-order and focus-visibility failures that block people outright. The checks are a floor, not a pass.

PART 6

Open items

Five places where the evidence is thinner than the recommendation resting on it. Every one needs a person outside this project — a customs broker, a tax adviser, a carrier, Airwallex — and none can be closed by writing more code.

Table 12: Unresolved, in rough order of cost if wrong

#	Item	Status	What to do
1	Cultural-relics export appraisal	Not established. Chinese government sources unreachable	Confirm a living artist's new work is not 文物 before the first export
2	EU reduced art VAT rates	Unverified. Directive (EU) 2022/542 changed art VAT from 2025	Do not publish per-country rates yet
3	Carrier costs and insurance from China	No verified figures	Needed before the shipping page is final
4	Export declaration for a \$300 painting	Not established	Also determines what supports the bank's FX check
5	Airwallex + HK sole proprietorship	Entity list verified for account opening only	Ask before incorporating

6.1 Closed since the first draft

Three items that were open have been settled in the build itself.

Table 13: Closed, and where

Item	Resolution	Where
CJK webfont strategy	The display face is subset to the ~100 characters that appear in headings, work titles and UI labels: 34 KB, from a 24 MB face. <code>unicode-range</code> gates the fetch, so an English page never downloads it, and a character added before the next build falls through to the system face rather than rendering as tofu. Chinese body prose is deliberately not webfont-served.	<code>scripts/build-fonts-cjk.py</code>
Leonardo's hatching angle	Recorded in the stylesheet as a measurement rather than a citation, with the caveat that two chalk sheets ran the other way	<code>src/styles/base.css</code>
Mona Lisa glaze layer count	The thickness is cited; the count is not, and the comment says why	<code>src/styles/tokens.css</code>
No logo	A mark that carries no letterforms, so one file serves both locales, generated from a single geometry for the tab, the home screen, the masthead and this document	<code>scripts/mark.mjs</code>
The report's own Chinese subset	Was built by hand, with <code>cjk-chars.txt</code> recording what somebody had built and nothing checking it still matched the prose. It is now derived from the <code>.qmd</code> on every build, and instanced to Regular first — subsetting the variable original silently yields ExtraLight , which is what the statutory quotations would have been set in	<code>docs/report/fonts.py</code>
The report's screenshots	Were taken by hand in a section that claims to show what the build produces. Now taken from <code>dist/</code> by script	<code>docs/report/shots.sh</code>

6.2 Content still outstanding

The build reports every placeholder; 48 fields are still `NEEDS-INPUT`. The blocking ones are the photographs, the titles and descriptions, and the contact details — the email and phone are not optional, they are the consumer-law requirement in Section 4.2.

One design item is also still open. The Chinese-locale enquiry route should be WeChat rather than a `mailto:`, and that needs a QR image that does not exist yet; the label was fixed, the channel was not.

Appendix: sources and method

Colour. Ratios computed with the WCAG 2 relative-luminance formula. The draft's values were extracted from the PDF content stream rather than sampled from a render, so they are declared values. Figures in this document read the project's live token file.

Fonts. Built with fonttools 4.59.1 from the variable originals; byte counts are measured output, not estimates.

Reachability from mainland China. Measured against a GFW measurement service, with known-blocked controls validating the method before any result was accepted.

Regulatory material. Chinese provisions read from `gov.cn` and `safe.gov.cn`; EU instruments from the Publications Office; US tariff treatment from the HTSUS and the Federal Register. Article numbers are given so each can be checked.

Layout. Verified by headless screenshot at 1440 px and 390 px, not by description. Three defects were found that way and are recorded in the commit history. The captures in Section 2.7 are taken from `dist/` by `docs/report/shots.sh` as part of this document's build, so they cannot show a version of the site that is no longer shipping.

The mark. Figure 3 and the mark in this document's footer are both drawn from `mark.mjs`, the one file the site's icons and its masthead are generated from. The TikZ copy of those numbers in the preamble is checked against it on every build. The hanging figure of 144.78 cm is the museum standard already used by the scale diagram on every work page.

Index

Airwallex, 1, 23

Alipay, 24

Cloudflare Pages, 2

Consumer Rights Directive, 29

de minimis, 1, 26

Fraunces, 6

Hong Kong entity, 2, 24

HS heading 9701, 26

ICP filing, 2

Leonardo da Vinci, 16

PIPL, 30

returns, 29

Rome I Regulation, 29

SAMR Order 37, 24

sanguine, 16

Section 301, 1, 26

sfumato, 16

Stripe, 1, 23

van Gogh, Vincent, 16

WCAG, 30

WeChat Pay, 24

wordmark, 7